Australia and the Vietnam War



AUSTRALIAN WAR MEMORIAL P01404.028

Year 10

Name:

History Set:

Class Teacher:

Approaching Sources:

There are four types of source question you should be prepared for on the Mid-Year Examination

- **Extract information from sources (According to Source A…)**
- **Using Source A and your own knowledge**
- **Identifying the perspective of a source**
- **Explaining the value of a source**

Each of these is asking for a slightly different thing and calls for different approaches

Extract information from sources (According to Source A…)

- Wants you to find the answer in the source
- Your knowledge will help you make sense of the source, but should not be included

Worked Example: According to Source A, what were two challenges Australian troops faced in Vietnam? (2 Marks)

Source A: Extract *from The 5th Battalion's Approach to Counter-Insurgency, 1966* by Dr Robert O'Neill

When we were out on operations, a normal carrying load was around 30 kilograms. This included a lightweight, foldable shelter, water, food for up to five days, a weapon, claymore mines for ambushing, grenades and, heaviest of all, ammunition both for one's own weapon and for the heavy consumers such as our general purpose machine guns. Often there were additional heavy items to be portered such as bombs for our mortars. Patrols and platoons had to carry radios (for tactical communications, not entertainment) and their heavy batteries to be shared around whatever group needed them. The prevailing heat and humidity caused copious sweating, and the pressure of pack straps gave us sore shoulders as a constant accompaniment to patrolling.

Solution: Australian troops had to carry 30kg of supplies when they were patrolling. The weather was also humid and hot.

Using Source A and your own knowledge

- This is a normal content question, but you have been given a source to help you
- Your own knowledge should form the basis of your answer
- Start by thinking about what your answer to the question would be if the source wasn't there, then work out how to make use of the source
- This will normally either be to provide an **argument** or **evidence for an argument**
- You **MUST** make explicit reference to the source in this kind of question
- A good way to test that you have done this is to ensure that your answer says **'Source A'** at some point

Worked Example: Using Source A and your own knowledge, outline how 1ATF patrolled in the Vietnam War. (4 Marks)

Source A: Photo of Australian troops patrolling in 1965



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Answer:

1ATF generally used patrolling in the countryside in Phuoc Tuy to look for signs of the enemy in order to set up ambushes. They generally moved in complete silence, using hand signals and maintaining at least five metres between each soldier, with stealth and concealment prioritised above all else. They often moved in single file, as can be seen in Source A, though they sometimes used diamond formation. Before nightfall, a patrol base would be established, with scrapes dug, Claymores set and sentries posted.

Identifying the perspective of a source

- This question is essentially asking 'What is the view of this source?'
- This means focusing on two main questions:
    - Who created the source?
        - Think about name (could be of a person or an organisation), position/role, date
        - Think also about what type of source it is and what that might tell us about its purpose
        - In cases where the question doesn't explicitly tell you who is responsible for the creation of a source, you may need to infer this
    - What is the view of the source?
        - What is the person / organisation saying?
        - Are they critical? Supportive? Outlining? Trying to persuade you of something?
- You will need to go beyond what is in the description of the source in order to get full marks
    - Read what's actually in the source and identify key argument(s)
    - You will need to link what you've been given to your own knowledge to draw a conclusion about what the source is trying to say / argue

Worked Example: Identify the perspective of Source A. (3 Marks)

Source A: An extract from a petition sent to the Australian magazine on 19 June 1965
The undersigned young Australian male citizens, being of an age making us liable for military service, declare that WE OPPOSE OVERSEAS CONSCRIPTION because—
We believe that we may be sent to fight in Vietnam …This would be a moral wrong and an unjust call upon our lives by the Government of our country. We share a fundamental belief that to safeguard the future of our nation, Australia's role in these perilous times is to seek an end to South East Asian disputes, through negotiations for peaceful settlements—not to pursue the murderous path to world conflict, through prolonging the slaughter in Vietnam.

Answer: Source A is an extract from a petition written by an unnamed group of young men and published on 19 June 1965, not long after Australia announced it was sending ground troops to Vietnam. The young men are critical of Australia sending conscripted troops to Vietnam. They argue that diplomacy would be a better solution. They are also concerned by the violence and believe that Australian involvement will prolong the civil war.

Explaining the value of a source

- Asks you to work out why someone might use this source when writing a book or studying the subject – what about the source is valuable?
    - Your own knowledge will help you make sense of why the source is useful
- Answer is likely to revolve around perspective and content, and possibly form
    - Perspective – Why is this person's view valuable? Why do we want something from this person?
        - Possible Value – Expertise/knowledge, unique/rare, official position
    - Form – Why is this type of source valuable?
        - Eg Why might a photo be useful for this topic? Why might a memoir be useful? Why might an overview of the battle be useful?
    - Content – What does the source say? What might that be valuable?
        - Possible Value – Does the source suggest an argument? Does the source provide evidence for an argument?
        - Is it valuable for a particular period? Eg experiences in the early years etc
        - Is it valuable for impacts on a group? Reasons for victory? Causes? etc
        - For a visual source, you're looking for what the source *shows*: try to be more specific than just what you can see in the source if you can

Worked Example: Explain the value of Source A for an Historian studying the reasons for Australian involvement in the Vietnam War (5 Marks)

Source A: Extract from a 2021 journal article written by Dr Tom Richardson, *Australia in Vietnam and Afghanistan.*

The world view of the Australian politicians who committed to Vietnam was underpinned by several fundamental beliefs. They were staunch anti-Communists who thought, unlike those on the Left, that the conflicts spreading across Asia in the 1950s and 1960s were not the fruits of decolonization but part of a broader global struggle between democracy and Communism. After touring South Vietnam in July 1962 Foreign Minister Garfield Barwick wrote to Defence Minister Townley: 'This place should be regarded as our present frontier. We should give the locals as much support as we can.' For these men, the domino theory was not just a political construct – although they certainly exploited it domestically – but a genuinely held belief.

Answer: Source A is an extract from a journal article written by a military historian Dr Tom Richardson which is valuable as it written by an expert who specialises in military history. He is likely to have a great deal of detailed knowledge on the subject and has written the article with the intention of educating the public. As a journal article, its claims would have been checked by the editor. As a recent article, the source reflects up-to-date scholarship.
The source's content is valuable because it provides an overview of the reasons for Australian involvement – anti-communism, regional concerns, and Australia being part of a broader, global community. He also provides evidence for his claims with a quote from the Foreign Minister which adds weight to his claims.

Do: Would You Go to War?

Imagine each of the following situations. For each, decide if you would support Australia going to war. Record your reason(s) in the appropriate column.

SITUATION	SHOULD AUSTRALIA GO TO WAR?	REASONS
Australia has been attacked by Country X		
Country X is threatening to attack Australia		
Country X is building up arms and might attack Australia later		
Country X is likely to be an enemy in the future		
An ally of Australia in the region has been attacked by Country X		
An ally of Australia in another part of the world has been attacked by Country X		
Country X has a brutal dictator who is oppressing its people		
There is a civil war in Country X and one side is more pro-Australia		
Australia's biggest ally has attacked Country X and asked for support		

Read & Research: Political Ideologies

Read the table below and highlight what you see as the three most important differences between Communism and Capitalism. Then answer the following questions – most of these are based on your opinion, but you may need to do some research for a few of them.

Communism: a theory or system of social organization in which property is owned by the community and each person contributes and receives according to their ability and needs.

Capitalism: an economic and political system in which a country's trade and industry are controlled by private owners for profit.

COMMUNISM	CAPITALISM
Economic and political ideology in which property is owned collectively by the community	Economic and political ideology in which a country's trade and industry are controlled by private owners for profit
Each person contributes according to their ability and receives according to their needs	Each person receives according to their contribution
Goods are state-owned and distributed evenly among the people	Goods are privately owned and not distributed evenly, creating class distinctions
Normally has an authoritarian form of government	Normally has a democratic form of government
Society is classless and equal	Society has social classes separated by lifestyle and wealth
Profit from trade and products are shared by the people or entire community	Profit from trade and products belong to specific private individuals or entities
Market is state-owned and state-controlled	Market is free and independent, controlled by market forces with only some government intervention

1. List 5 communist countries: _____

   _____

   _____

   _____

2. List 5 capitalist countries: _____

   _____

   _____

   _____

What would be the impact for these groups if a country became Communist?		
Group	Positives	Negatives
Wealthy		
Workers		
Middle Class		
Unemployed		
Politicians		
Students		
Other Group: _____		

3. Do you think Australia should become Communist? Why/why not?

Read: Why were Australians afraid of Communism?

The below is edited extracts from a 2004 speech by Associate Professor ***David McKnight*** *about the Cold War. As you read each section, write a one sentence answer to the question in the subheading. Then, highlight any argument or evidence McKnight suggests about why Australian politicians and the public were afraid of Communism during the Cold War.*

<u>What was the Cold War?</u>



I want to begin by defining what we mean by the Cold War. Many people attribute the phrase to the British writer, George Orwell, whose used the term 'cold war' in 1945 to contrast that period to a period of hot war - that is a war involving guns and bombs. But this is a little misleading. During the Cold war, it is true, that there was no direct military conflict between the communist bloc and the capitalist West, though the Cuban Missile Crisis in the early 1960s nearly caused nuclear war.

But the Cold War did involve plenty of guns and bombs-type conflicts. There was, for example, the Korean war and later the Vietnam war, both costing millions of lives as well as a strong of smaller wars. Whatever their local and specific causes, these conflicts were fought as wars by proxy between the US and communist bloc.

The transition to what became known as the Cold War happened very rapidly - just in the space of a few years - because when World War Two ended, the US, Britain, Australia were in alliance with the Soviet Union. But, by 1948 it was clear that the victorious Soviet Union was determined to colonize eastern Europe -- which it did with some brutality.

How did early developments in the Cold War lead to Australian fears about Communism?

Early developments like the Berlin Airlift symbolized to many people in the West that communism simply denied civil freedoms which they took for granted. Propaganda images showing stern-faced Soviet troops marshalling breadlines painted a stark picture of what life under a Communist regime would look like. The popularity of the phrase 'the Iron Curtain' which appears so melodramatic today, had some popular currency at the time.

In the late 1940s Communism was on the move elsewhere. In former colonies of Europe strong independence movements emerged, often with communists playing key roles. In Malaya and Vietnam such struggles ensued against respectively the British and French colonial powers. Most significant of all, was the communist victory in China in 1949 which sent shock waves around the world and gave rise to a belief that even more countries would fall like a line of dominos. In Australia this victory later allowed the Right to speak of a double-barreled fear of a red (Communist) and yellow (Racial) peril. And all these fears were heightened when the Soviet Union detonated its own atomic bomb in 1949, breaking the US monopoly.



Why did Robert Menzies try to ban the Australian Communist Party?

At home in Australia, the communist party -- the CPA -- was on the move as well. It emerged confidently from the Second World War with a large membership and a powerful base in the

unions. It also had big plans. Initially, the challenge it made was within the labour movement. The bitter coal strike of 1949 was a first sign, but in many other industries, the CPA urged a strongly militant stance and strikes were widespread.

The 1949 election saw the Liberal and Country parties win a majority, with a promise of being tough on Communism an important part of Menzie's campaign. Once in office he lost no time in drawing up a law to ban the CPA. Menzies regarded the communists as a treasonable force. So shortly after the bill banning the Communist Party passed through parliament, a series of raids on communist offices and the homes of CPA officials took place around Australia.

The Communists responded by challenging the law in court, with the High Court striking it down in March 1951 for violating the constitution. Menzies responded with a referendum the following September to change the constitution which was defeated by the narrowest of margins, 50.56% to 49.44%.

Extract from the official YES case – 1951 Referendum Pamphlet

'Communist activity in Australia has become a grave menace to our industrial peace, to production, to national security and defence. It is the enemy of defence and progress; it is the friend of inflation and disorder.

Australian Communist leaders have worked their way into positions of leadership in key trades unions, such as those relating to Coal-mining [sic], Shipping, Waterside work, Iron-working [sic], and Transport.

Unless we can meet and defeat this conspiracy in the next year or two years, we may find ourselves driven into a defensive world war inadequately prepared, and with insufficient resources.

FOR THE SAKE OF OUR SECURITY, PEACE AND DECENT PROSPERITY OF OUR COUNTRY, WE ASK YOU TO VOTE YES.'

<u>Why were Australian people and politicians so afraid of Communism?</u>

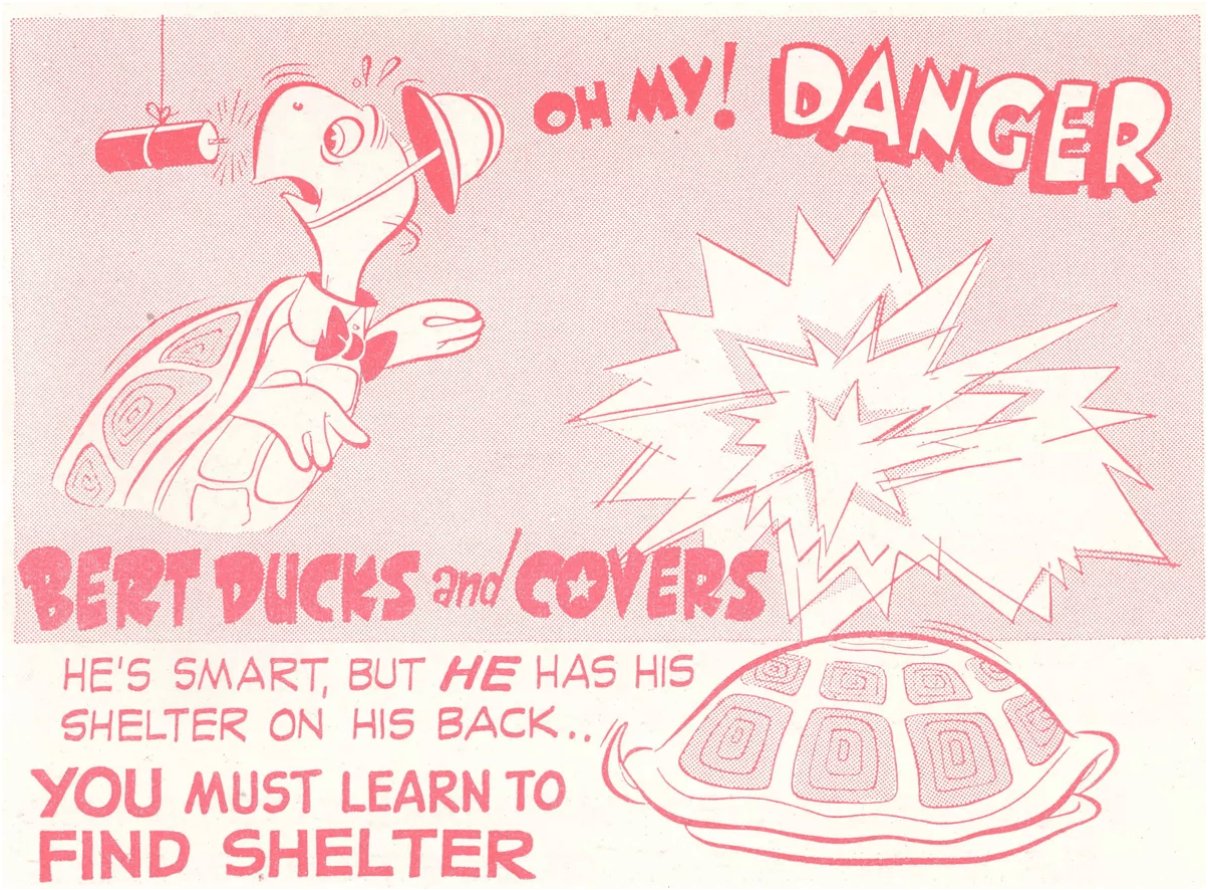
To many people this remains one of the puzzles of the early cold war. To us today the message about the fear of communism appears exaggerated, hyped, and hysterical. And it is certainly true that fear of communism was a very politically useful weapon which the conservative parties used to great effect at election after election. Beating the anti-Communist drum seemed

to drown out discussion on any other issues and to scare people into singing the one tune or staying silent. The accusation of communism was able to close off debate and shut people up.

But the puzzle remains: why were these fears accepted by a large number of people? Why was the accusation of communism so potent a weapon?

It is of course very easy to judge a previous historical period. The people are always more stupid than us - or more naïve - or more noble. Hindsight is a wonderful thing. But the people and the political players of the cold war were in fact very much like us - in the given circumstances of the time.

One of the challenges for people studying the Cold War is to try to think our way into the feeling of the times. For example, it gradually became obvious to me that my picture of the former ASIO officers and politicians some of whom I interviewed and about whose files I read were rather different from what I imagined. I had imagined that they were a rather grim, fanatical bunch who opposed the high minded and idealistic lefties who wanted to change Australia for the better. What I realised was that many of the ASIO officers and the anti-communists were of course, also idealists. And that in many ways the things which they did - and with which I disagreed - were the action of idealists - driven by ideals to sacrifice some freedoms in the passionate belief that that this was necessary to save even greater freedoms. Driven by ideals to label people who disagreed as soft on communism.



The other challenge to understand the cold war is one faced by anyone looking at history back over 60 years. And that is, that when we look backwards, we have to realise that what is now in the past was once in the future.

For example, we now know as a simple matter of fact that no direct conflict occurred between the Soviet Union and the West in the 1950s. But looking toward the future from a standpoint in 1950, this was by no means clear. A third world war was a possibility, it was genuinely believed. Western intelligence and defence officials sincerely believed that a Third World War with their erstwhile ally, the Soviet Union, could soon break out. Moreover, this view was shared by the intelligence and defence officials of the Soviet Union, which made various preparations, including alerting communist parties around the world to be ready.



In this climate, it makes sense that politicians on the right and intelligence officers, not to mention the Australian public, were afraid of Communism. They were concerned that Stalin -- whom they knew was responsible for mass murder of his own people -- was armed with the Atomic bomb. We now know that no Third World war ever took place. But this was not known in 1952 or 1953 or 54.

A final reason for Australian fears about Communism was the apparent progress it was making globally. As the debate around the Referendum swirled in Australia, North Korea had invaded South Korea and Australian troops and pilots were sent to fight there. But while a majority of Australians judged Menzies had gone too far with his ban on the CPA, for many people the fear of communism remained a legitimate concern because of the communism's victories overseas. These in turn created a climate in which many people began to believe that a new war would become possible. And for people who had just suffered a war this was a potent fear.

Watch: The Domino Theory

Watch the video at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TAXLuJJuCN8 and answer the questions which follow on the Domino Theory

1. What was the Domino Theory?

2. How did the Domino Theory influence American thinking about Vietnam?

3. What actions did the US take as a result of Domino Theory fears?

4. What event debunked the Domino Theory?

Do: Domino Theory Source Activity

Source A: A press conference given by Dwight D. Eisenhower on April 7th, 1954.

First of all, you have the specific value of a locality in its production of materials that the world needs. "Now, with respect to the first one, two of the items from this particular area that the world uses are tin and tungsten. They are very important. There are others, of course, the rubber plantations and so on.

Then you have the possibility that many human beings pass under a dictatorship that is inimical to the free world. "Then with respect to more people passing under this domination, Asia, after all, has already lost some 450 million of its peoples to the Communist dictatorship, and we simply can't afford greater losses.

Finally, you have broader considerations that might follow what you would call the 'falling domino' principle. You have a row of dominoes set up, you knock over the first one, and what will happen to the last one is the certainty that it will go over very quickly. So you could have a beginning of a disintegration that would have the most profound influences.

"But when we come to the possible sequence of events, the loss of Indochina, of Burma, of Thailand, of the Peninsula, and Indonesia following, now you begin to talk about areas that not only multiply the disadvantages that you would suffer through loss of materials, sources of materials, but now you are talking really about millions and millions and millions of people.

"Finally, the geographical position achieved thereby does many things. It turns the so-called island defensive chain of Japan, Formosa, of the Philippines and to the southward; it moves in to threaten Australia and New Zealand.

"So, the possible consequences of the loss are just incalculable to the free world."

1. Identify the perspective of Source A. (3 Marks)

2. Explain the value of Source A for an historian studying the reasons for US involvement in Vietnam (4 Marks)

3. According to Source A, why were the US concerned about possibility of a Communist state in Vietnam? (3 Marks)

